3

AGASTYA’S COUNTRY



The stone colossus of the Tamil sage Thiruvalluvar facing Kanyakumari and the walls of the *kovil*.

Stepping out of the car at Kanyakumari I find myself in the market-place of a very ordinary, dusty, noisy Indian town, its main street crowded with holidaymakers doubling as pilgrims – or is it vice versa?

What they have come to see lies immediately offshore: two islets side by side, but not quite as drawn by the geologist Robert Foote back in 1860 (as shown at the start of Chapter 1). One carries a neat stone temple, topped by half a dozen pink Indo-Saracenic domes. This was built in